

“Future nations will know ... **smallpox** has existed and by you **has been extirpated.**”

Thomas Jefferson, 1806

the rest of his life, Hunter instilled the young Jenner with the Enlightenment motto, “Don’t think, try.”

After 3 years of study in London, in 1773, Jenner qualified as a doctor and returned to his place of birth to set up a medical practice. Having grown up in an agricultural area, he was aware that catching cowpox—a relatively benign disease—somehow prevented smallpox. Milkmaids, for instance, rarely contracted smallpox if they had previously caught cowpox due to contact with their cows.



By giving patients cowpox to fight smallpox, Jenner discovered the principle of vaccination. When a body is invaded by a virus, like cowpox, it produces antibodies, which protect it against reinfection.

